



# BIKEROUTES, GREENWAYS AND BICYCLE TOURING

DEVELOPMENT ISSUES AND INTERNATIONAL PERSPECTIVES

COMMENTS AND OBSERVATIONS FROM THE INTERNATIONAL MOBILE FORUM ON QUÉBEC'S ROUTE VERTE



# Québec's Route verte

## International Mobile Forum Itinerary

## Introduction

This is the third in a series of reports on the Route verte and the development of bicycle touring in Québec. The first two reports were entitled *Le cyclotourisme au Québec à l'heure de la Route verte* (1999) and *Tourisme et vélo: vers l'inauguration de la Route verte* (2004), both of which were prepared by the Transat Chair in Tourism in preparation for conferences on these issues.

This report on bikeways, greenways and bicycle touring is a compilation of the information gathered from participants of the International Mobile Forum, which was held from August 5 to 10, 2007, to mark the official launch of the Route verte.



CLAUDE GILL

## Beyond the Ribbon-Cutting

Some one hundred events were held during the summer of 2007 to mark the unveiling of the Route verte, including the official inauguration ceremonies and Le Grand Tour in Québec City on August 10, the Destination Route verte•07 tour from Ville-Marie to Gaspé, and the International Mobile Forum. All of these activities brought together a number of cycling enthusiasts as well as the partners and architects of the bikeroute.

Any ribbon-cutting is a major achievement in itself, but it also represents an opportunity to look to the future and prepare for the challenges ahead. Topping the list of priorities for the Route verte are the completion of the missing portions of the bikeroute and various enhancements required to optimize the existing network and overall cycling and tourism experience. The need to ensure the long-term viability of the network is also vital.

Because of its sheer size and characteristics, the Route verte now ranks among the world's leading bikeways. But the competition is fierce. The National Cycle Network in the United Kingdom has grown from 5,000 miles in 2000 to 10,000 miles today. In 2001, the North Sea Cycle Route unveiled its 6,000-kilometre chain to the international community. And last year, EuroVelo 6, running from the Atlantic Ocean to the Black Sea, added 4,000 kilometres to the EuroVelo network. In the spring of 2008, the Cycling in Switzerland Foundation will be launching SwitzerlandMobility, an integrated network for cyclists and other outdoor enthusiasts, with facilities for hiking, inline skating, canoeing and mountain biking.

Throughout the development of the Route verte project, we were constantly inspired by the initiatives associated with these and other major bike routes around the world. In fact, the International Mobile Forum was organized as a result of our interest in and admiration for the work of our counterparts in other countries. The approach we adopted, although challenging from an organizational standpoint, was conceptually quite

simple: bring together a group of experts, have them cycle across a section of the Route verte over six successive days and give them an opportunity to discuss issues of interest with local and regional stakeholders.

The representatives of these major cycling organizations,



GAËTAN FONTAINE

whom we had the pleasure of hosting, eagerly accepted our invitation and shared with us their expertise on several specific themes, namely the long-term viability of bicycle routes, bikeways as a part of transportation infrastructure, selection of destination, information provided to cycle tourists, signage and continuous improvement. During the course of the week, these presentations sparked some animated discussions while in transit. After further rumination and contemplation, and with the help of Gilles Morneau, a reporter with Vélo Mag, we have compiled their contributions and put together this report.

We hope you find the contents useful and enlightening.

Yours in cycling,

Jean-François Pronovost  
Executive Director  
Vélo Québec Association



YAN LASSALLE

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**Publisher** Vélo Québec Association  
**Programming Committee for the International Mobile Forum** Michel Archambault, Transat Chair in Tourism  
Louis Carpentier, Vélo Québec Association  
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**Sponsorships and Partners for the inauguration of the Route verte** Government of Québec, Tourism partnership fund, Proxim and Gaz Métro

## THANK YOU!

Vélo Québec would like to thank all those who contributed to the success of each of the sessions of the International Mobile Forum, which were held in the Laurentians, Montréal, Montérégie, Eastern Townships, Centre-du-Québec, Mauricie and Capitale-Nationale regions.



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Legal Deposit – Bibliothèque et Archives nationales  
du Québec, 2007  
ISBN 978-2-922418-14-9

COVER PHOTOS:  
GAËTAN FONTAINE, CLAUDE GILL, MATHIEU LAMARRE, NORTH SEA CYCLE ROUTE





YAN LASSALLE

## From Local to National: The Challenge of Preserving Long-Term Viability

### Looking to the Future

Getting a project as vast in scope as the Route verte off the ground is a colossal undertaking. Once the ribbon is cut, however, another daunting challenge awaits administrators and all those involved in the day-to-day management: preserving its long-term viability. The newly established network needs to



"La Campagnarde entails 65 km of bikeway to maintain, all for a population of about 6,000. The community simply doesn't have the means to pay for this."

Réjean Parent

mature gracefully. It has to establish its personality, grow and improve with age. It has to be managed effectively, with daily upkeep to protect against deterioration. The medium- and long-term renewal of the network infrastructure has to be well planned in advance. All these activities require funding and the concerted effort of many different partners.

Réjean Parent, head of the Association des réseaux cyclables du Québec, in an introduction to a presentation on this topic, summarized the issues facing Québec managers in this regard.

Funding for the development of the Route verte was provided by Transports Québec (25%) and local and regional agencies (75%). Maintenance costs, however, will be split equally between the two groups. In other words, every dollar invested by regional county municipalities (RCMs) or municipal governments will be matched by Transports Québec.

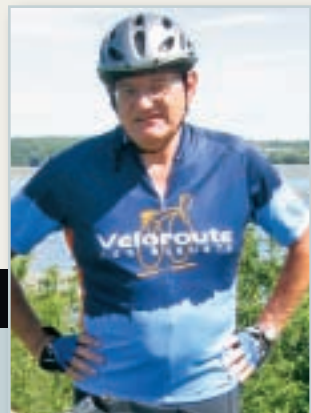
This approach works well in most situations, but it is difficult to apply in rural areas, where the trails are generally less used and where municipal budgets are much smaller than those allotted to cities.

Réjean Parent also pointed out that an exceptionally large number of stakeholders are involved in the Route verte. It crosses more than 300 communities, which translates into a huge group of people to contact and unite. The solution is to form several coordinating bodies to ensure that all these voices are represented. The Véloroute des Bleuets in the Saguenay—Lac-Saint-Jean region is an excellent example of this.

### Réjean Parent

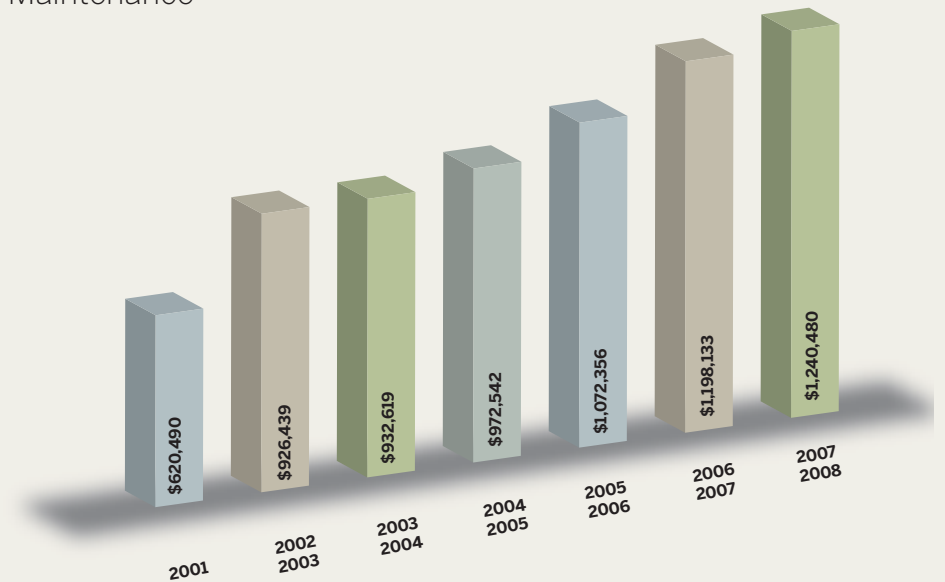
Association des réseaux cyclables du Québec, Québec

Réjean Parent has been involved in the development of biking networks and the promotion of bicycle touring in Québec for over eight years. He is currently the President of the Association des réseaux cyclables du Québec and Vice-President of Tourisme Montérégie. An avid cyclist, he has ridden the Route des Mille-Îles and Véloroute des Bleuets in Canada and the magnificent Danube route from Passau to Vienna in Europe (summer 2007). He has also travelled from Amsterdam to Brugge as part of a "bike and barge" tour.

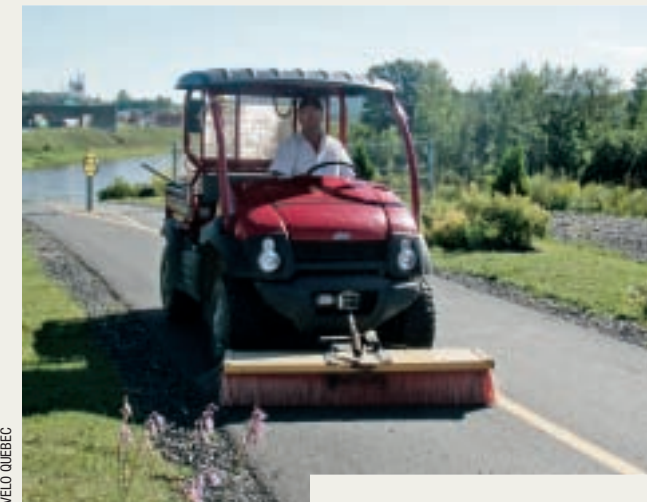


ANDY CLARKE

Financial Aid for the Route verte's Maintenance  
Funding from 2001-2008



Source: Transports Québec



VELO QUÉBEC

The presentations during the International Mobile Forum confirmed that many of the difficulties identified in Québec are in fact universal; they also took a closer look at some of the solutions that have been implemented in Europe. Carmen Aycart Luengo, of the Fundación de los Ferrocarriles Españoles, described the national cycling network in her country. Built entirely on former railway rights-of-way, the network is currently 1,600 kilometres long. Management and maintenance costs run between 2,100 and 2,800 euros per kilometre, depending on the section.

In Spain, unlike Québec and the United States, the transportation department is not involved in the development of bikeways. Rather the environment department provides 70% of the funding for the construction of the network, with the rest coming from the national health department and other governmental agencies.

Maintenance costs are allocated in the same proportions for the first two years, following which the responsibility falls to the municipalities. The 480 municipalities are divided up into 18 consortiums or communities. Local citizens' groups and associations representing environmentalists, cyclists and disabled persons play a vital role in this regard. Private railway companies, through the Fundación de los Ferrocarriles Españoles, make unused rights-of-way available and ensure coordination with the various parties. The foundation helps its partners develop the necessary infrastructure by facilitating the exchange of information, providing documentation and overseeing promotional activities.

With 7,600 kilometres of former railway rights-of-way available for the Vías Verdes project and 1,600 kilometres of greenways developed to date, the Fundación de los Ferrocarriles Españoles has its work cut out for it in the coming years. Considering that Spain is the second hilliest country in Europe, after Switzerland, existing railway infrastructure is extensive, with more than 500 bridges and tunnels and some 950 train stations. Built in the last century, these facilities all require ex-

### Carmen Aycart Luengo

Vías Verdes, Spain

A graduate of the University of Seville (geography and history), Carmen Aycart Luengo has been the director of the Vías Verdes greenway program of the Fundación de los Ferrocarriles Españoles (Spanish Railway Foundation) since it was established in 1993. The foundation is responsible for the development of 1,600 kilometres of bikeways throughout Spain. The Vías Verdes program was honoured for its best practices by the United Nations Habitat Program in 2000 and received a Panda Award from the World Wildlife Fund/Adena for the best institutional environmental communication initiative in 2006.



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[www.viasverdes.com](http://www.viasverdes.com)





VÍAS VERDES

tensive renovation and maintenance. The situation is not unlike the one in Québec, where bridges along many lines will require significant work in the coming years.

The Fundación de los Ferrocarriles Españoles has produced a useful guide for the communities involved in this process, with 100 practical management tips and information on how bikeways contribute to rural development.

The benefits of cycling paths and trails for local economies were also recognized by Eli Viten, of the North Sea Cycle



NORTH SEA CYCLE ROUTE

**“The route is complete. We are now working with the regions to broaden the selection of attractions and accommodations. We are using several examples from neighbouring countries to help convince private operators to support these efforts.”**

**Eli Viten**

Route, who noted that “long-distance bike routes play a decisive role in the global economy.”

The North Sea Cycle Route is an ambitious undertaking. To ensure its long-term viability, some 2.8 million euros were invested in the project between 1998 and 2006. As a result, a permanent administrative structure was established, the network was extended to Belgium and the Dutch province of Zeeland, a study was conducted on the use and economic benefits of the Route, and the website was completely revamped to ensure maximum visibility. Several weaknesses were also identified and certain systems were improved (service areas, parking, bikeway surfacing). Enhancements to nearby services and amenities are ongoing.

The management and maintenance costs of the North Sea Cycle Route are paid by the eight countries it runs through, based on the relative number of kilometres attributable to each. The money from each country is generally provided by regional authorities. Starting in 2007, a shared online platform will be the primary source of general promotional information. Marketing efforts will be supported by partnerships formed with other European routes.

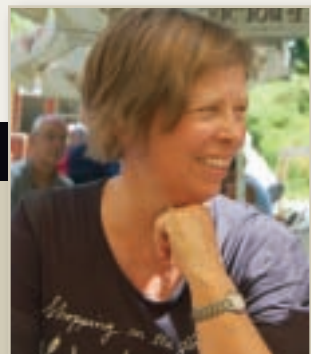
A network of this size has the advantage of being able to tap into a wide range of experiences from each of the participating countries. For example, a problem encountered with respect to the Norwegian coasts was solved using an approach that had proven successful in Belgium.

According to Jim Sayer, of the Adventure Cycling Association, in the United States, the challenge of long-term viability can be overcome by consolidating thousands of cycling routes located throughout a vast region. Countries that have devel-

## Eli Viten

North Sea Cycle Route, Norway

Eli Viten earned a degree in geography from the University of Bergen, in Norway, in 1982. She specializes in the development of recreational facilities and has worked for the Regional Development Department of the County of Rogaland in Stavanger, Norway, for 20 years. Since 1998, she has headed up the North Sea Cycle Route, a 6,000-kilometre network crossing the United Kingdom, Belgium, the Netherlands, Germany, Denmark, Sweden and Norway, all of which border the North Sea. The route was established thanks to the cooperation of 68 regional authorities and is partially funded by two European Union programs (Interreg-IIC and IIIB North Sea). The County of Rogaland coordinates these two programs.



BERNHARD ENSINK

[www.northsea-cycle.com](http://www.northsea-cycle.com)



NORTH SEA CYCLE ROUTE

**“From a marketing perspective, Québec’s tourism cycling industry can gain a great deal from the Route verte, which has a strong brand image among cycle tourists and enjoys a unique position in foreign markets.”**

*Le cyclotourisme au Québec: plan de développement et de commercialisation,*  
Groupe DBSF on behalf of the Table de concertation sectorielle sur le cyclotourisme, September 2006.

oped national cycling networks have been the most successful in this regard. From 2000 to 2005, the U.S. cycling network grew from 4,000 kilometres to 10,000 kilometres, and usage skyrocketed from 85 million to 239 million trips a year. The current situation in the U.S. can be likened to an enormous plate of spaghetti – a jumble of individual bikeways that in many cases do not connect past state boundaries. An inventory has been performed and a structure for primary and secondary corridors has been recommended. The next step will be to unite the various routes under a common identity and establish a strong, unique brand image.



## HIGHLIGHTS

### From Local to National: The Challenge of Preserving Long-Term Viability

- ⊗ The successful maintenance of bikeways, especially in rural areas, often requires the formation of coordinating bodies to represent the various stakeholders.
- ⊗ Political involvement in greenways is necessary given their impact on the economies of the areas where they are located.
- ⊗ The bigger the network, the more beneficial it is to share resources – and the more complex this becomes.
- ⊗ A strong, united brand image at the national level is an undeniable asset for a bikeway network.

## North Sea Cycle Route







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# Greenways as a Part of Transportation Systems

## Putting the Fun in Functional

Should cycling be looked upon as a leisure activity or a practical form of transportation? Are greenways essentially used by tourists or do they fulfill a useful purpose? Obviously, there is no one answer to these questions. Cycling has a dual role and is widely used as a functional means of transportation the world over. Today's cities are increasingly turning to bikes as a solution to the ever-growing problems of gridlock and pollution.

Surprisingly, authorities are often reluctant to acknowledge the legitimacy of cycling as a means of transportation. In the United States, as Andy Clarke from the League of American Bicyclists pointed out, cycling and walking account for 10% of travelling activity and 13% of road accidents, but only 2% of federal transportation funding. And the central government funds a mere 20% of development expenditures.

Nicolas Mercat, representative of the Association des Départements cyclables in France, pointed out that perceptions of greenways are split: elected officials generally see cycling as a recreational pursuit while associations tend to prioritize its functional nature. Mr. Mercat stressed that greenways represent a step forward in the promotion of the widespread, routine use of bicycles. They encourage cycling as an enjoyable leisure activity as well as an effective means of transportation to and from school. Greenway users are four times more likely to cycle for practical reasons than the average cyclist. Jim Sayer agreed. He sees a nation-wide cycling network as a way of encouraging more people to bike for fun (leisure, tourism), with the ultimate goal of promoting local city-friendly initiatives (transportation, commuting).

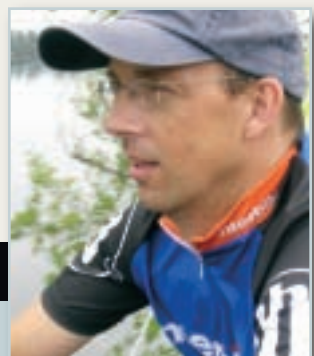
"If you build it, they will come." The famous quote from the Kevin Costner movie *Field of Dreams* can be interpreted here to mean that if you make bikeways available, people will

## Andy Clarke

League of American Bicyclists, USA

Andy Clarke is the Executive Director of the League of American Bicyclists, founded in 1880 as the League of American Wheelmen (LAW), the organization responsible for paving roads in the U.S. before the era of the automobile. Prior to joining the League in February 2003, Andy provided technical assistance to the Pedestrian and Bicycle Information Center. In addition, he managed a range of bicycle and pedestrian planning projects and worked extensively with advocacy groups at the state and local levels. He is a 1984 graduate of the University of Birmingham, United Kingdom, with an undergraduate degree in law.

[www.bikeleague.org](http://www.bikeleague.org)



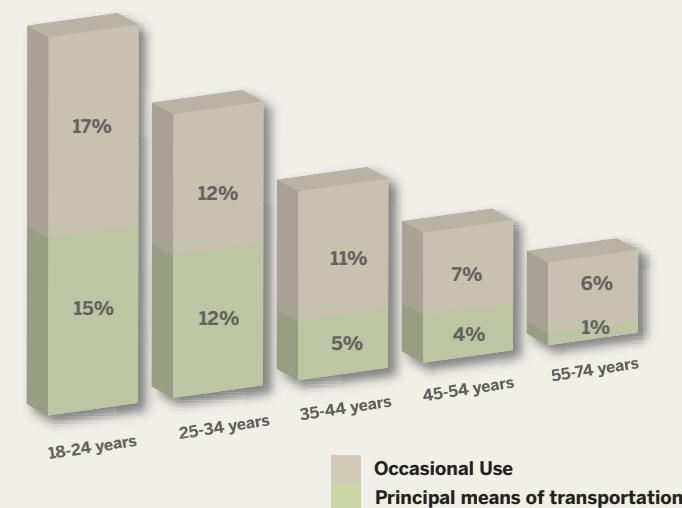
GILLES MORNEAU

"Our statistics show that 50% of greenway users were not regular cyclists before they had access to a nearby bikeway."

Nicolas Mercat



## Bicycle Use by Age Group



Source : *Bicycling in Québec in 2005*, Vélo Québec Association (2006)

start pedalling. The statistics speak loud and clear about the link between the presence of biking facilities and the prevalence of cycling. In France, the numbers show that cycling is more popular among those who live within five kilometres of a greenway and that greenway users are four times more likely to use their bikes for transportation.

In Portland, Oregon, the bikeway network grew from 135 kilometres (83 miles) in 1992 to 425 kilometres (263 miles) in 2006. Consequently, the number of daily bike commutes leapt from 2,850 to 12,000. In Québec, cycling enthusiasts use bikeways for 43% of their travelling. Montréal's bike lanes and paths welcome multitudes of cyclists every day – the Brébeuf path alone is ridden on 8,000 times a day on average.

## A Green Way to Go

In Québec, 16% of all cycling is for commuting or transportation purposes. This represents 330 million kilometres a year, which translates into savings of some 30 million litres of gas and 76,000 tonnes of CO<sub>2</sub>. Even though cycling is still a relatively small part of integrated transportation plans, its virtues are being recognized more and more for short city trips. Overlooked in environmental rhetoric until as recently as 10 or 15 years ago, bicycles now figure prominently in most sustainable development initiatives.

Bikeways that are designed primarily for tourism purposes are often used by locals as well. For example, the Ontario Waterfront Trail has become an important link between a series of riverfront communities. In the past 10 years, the incidence of practical cycling on the trail has risen from 14% to 24%.

## Two Wheels Instead of Four

In North America, as in France, there is a lingering misconception that bikes are for fun and cars are for practical use. In France, recreational and tourism use account for 50% of automobile travelling and 37% of greenhouse gases associated with this form of transportation. However, polls show that more and more travellers are eager to spend their vacations away from their cars.

In popular tourist destinations, cycling has a number of advantages. When a town's population grows from 10,000 to 200,000 in a matter of days during peak tourist seasons, bicycles are instrumental in helping to stave off traffic congestion. France's Île de Ré, for example, has 50,000 beds and 20,000 bikes for rent. About half of the visitors to the island opt to cycle during their stay.

In Pouliguen, in the Brittany region of France, the local road system has been reworked to deliberately make car traffic less efficient and minimize the availability of parking facilities. One car lane of a major thoroughfare was designated as a bike lane, notably to cater to the tourist population. Vacation cycling is the first step toward utilitarian cycling. After people find out how pleasurable it can be to get around on a bike, they often seek to repeat the experience in their day-to-day routine.



# Challenges and Rewards

## 1. Perception

There are a number of challenges inherent in biking. The first is recognition as an accepted form of routine transportation. As environmental issues become more and more important for elected officials, however, the situation is beginning to change. Around the world, governments are adopting national cycling policies, among them the U.K.'s National Cycling Strategy, the Netherlands' Bicycle Master Plan and Australia's National Cycling Strategy 2005-2010.

In France, recently adopted urban transportation plans have confirmed policymakers' interest in greenways, which are defined in the country's highway code as lanes and paths reserved for use by non-motorized vehicles. At intersections, the busiest lanes get priority, even if they are greenways. It is therefore possible that at the crossroads between a heavy-traffic bike lane and a less busy roadway, cars would have a required stop. It is hard to imagine a similar scenario arising in Québec, whose *Land Use Planning and Development Act* allows for the possibility of bikeways but does not make them compulsory. In the United States, cycling has gradually made its way into various pieces of federal legislation (ISTEA, TEA-21, SAFETEA-LU, etc.) and into transportation infrastructure and commuter funding policy. Each of these statutes is in its own way helping to secure the role of the bicycle as a means of transportation.

## 2. Funding

Acknowledging the legitimacy of cycling is not enough – it has to be backed by a solid financial commitment to its development. In his presentation on the U.S. strategy for funding bikeways, Andy Clarke quoted figures that showed an improvement in the situation in his country. Prior to 1991, public spending on clean transportation in the U.S. was practically nil. Today, thanks to an \$0.18 tax on every gallon of gas, more than \$4 billion is injected annually into clean transportation programs and facilities. With the support of the AARP, cyclists have successfully introduced the concept of complete streets, which accommodate the needs of all users (pedestrians, cyclists, motorists, youths, seniors, disabled persons) as well as residents and businesses.

## 3. Intermodality

Intermodality also represents an interesting challenge. With respect to the issue of the overall role of greenways in transportation, Nicolas Mercat pointed out that traffic at a train station increases significantly when it has direct access to a bikeway. Cycling being three times faster than walking, direct access to a bikeway can multiply by nine the distance people are willing to ride to get to the station. Generally speaking, in France some 2% of users make their way to a train station by bike. When a bikeway is added to the equation, this percentage climbs to 15%. In addition, the presence of bikeways means better bike facilities in trains, train stations and parking areas. The 18 bike parking areas across Switzerland can each accommodate 100 to 600 bikes. Germany has an even better record, with 40 bike parking areas, including one in Münster for 3,300 bicycles.



GILLES MORNEAU

## Nicolas Mercat

Association des Départements cyclables, France

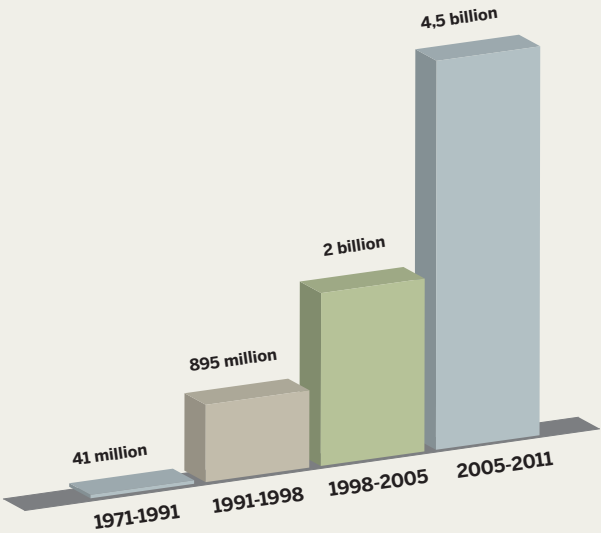
Nicolas Mercat is with the Association des Départements cyclables (ADC), which he helped establish in 1999 and which now represents 65 French departments, or approximately two-thirds of the country's regional governments. The ADC promotes the sharing of ideas and experiences with respect to cycling, bikeways and greenways. It organizes conferences and meetings and promotes interaction between government entities, organizations and associations. Nicolas is also the founder of Altermodal, a firm specializing in the development of cycling facilities. Altermodal has 30 engineers, urban planners and geographers on staff, all of whom boast an extensive knowledge of bikeways. Nicolas has also been one of the proponents of "Loire à vélo," a section of the EuroVelo 6 bikeway. In 1990-1991, he crossed Africa from north to south on a tandem bicycle. In 2002-2003, he rode around the world with his wife and three children, aged five to nine.



LUKAS STADTHER

[www.departements-cyclables.com](http://www.departements-cyclables.com)

## Federal Investment in the U.S.A. in Infrastructure for Pedestrians and Cyclists



Source: League of American Bicyclists



VELO QUÉBEC

Typical train station in The Netherlands

## 4. Promotion

Yet another issue facing cycling as a practical mode of transportation is the challenge of visibility. A growing section of the working population is more likely to consider cycling as a commuting option. They require incentives, facilities and encouragement to seal the deal. In the United States, contrary to popular belief, bikeways have an ample number of potential users. However, according to estimates from Shimano, 160 million Americans who have cycled no longer engage in the activity, in particular because they do not feel safe in traffic. The League of American Bicyclists uses a punchy slogan to try to drum up enthusiasm: "Cycling = health, wealth, freedom." The Dutch government has taken the promotion idea one step further by offering tax deductions to commuter cyclists.

Leading by example is key. City commuters greatly appreciate both the convenience of a bike in busy traffic and its social character, as opposed to the isolated experience of a car. In Québec, 23 of the 43 police departments in the province have bike patrols. Roving ambulance technicians are also becoming more common in several cities, especially during large public events. This is definitely not as widespread in Europe. In fact, when International Mobile Forum participants crossed paths with police, ambulance and Vélo-Sécur patrols on bikes, they were quick to approach them, ask questions and take notes.

## HIGHLIGHTS



### Greenways as a Part of Transportation Systems

- Ⓢ There are a number of challenges facing cycling, the most important being its recognition as a valid means of transportation.
- Ⓢ Acknowledging the legitimacy of cycling is one thing. Funding its widespread use is another.
- Ⓢ Bikeways are a good way to promote routine cycling. Users of bikeways are four times more likely to use their bicycle for commuting purposes. Vacation cycling is a good first step toward practical cycling.
- Ⓢ The presence of cycling facilities has a direct influence on the prevalence of cycling in any given population.
- Ⓢ Cycling being three times faster than walking, direct access to a bikeway can multiply by nine the distance people are willing to ride to get to the station.





# Selection of Destination

**Where Are We Going?** The Fédération française de cyclo-tourisme has published a guide to the more than 4,500 annual cycling tours organized by its various clubs. This, among other things, led the International Mobile Forum to ponder how cyclists decide on where to bike. How do they choose their destination? What criteria and tools do they use? How can we reach out to them and influence these decisions? During the conference, inspired by a presentation by Pierre Reuzé of the Fédération française de cyclotourisme, participants came up with some answers to these questions. An expert in bicycle touring in France, Pierre made the following points.

**Budget** is obviously the first consideration: money makes the (biking) world go around. Cycle tourists necessarily plan their vacations based on the funds they have on hand. The next logical consideration, then, is **place**. Depending on how tightly drawn their purse strings are, users may tend to stay in their own region, visit another part of the country, or head for foreign soil.

**Time** is also a major factor. A faraway destination requires several weeks of holiday time. Travellers will also look at the **other activities** available along the chosen routes. Cycling may be both the means and the end of the trip, but that is just the beginning. Once off the saddle, travellers are often eager to explore new places on foot and immerse themselves in local culture. They are therefore influenced by the complementary activities offered nearby. They may look specifically for walking tours, boat tours, horseback riding or other outdoor activities.

Some touring bicyclists turn to **organizations**, be they permanent or event-specific, for expertise, a planned itinerary and technical and logistical support. This is the “turnkey” approach to tourism which, according to the number of book-

ings made by Vélo Québec Voyages and other organizations, is a popular concept in Québec. This type of package is not as common in France, however; 90% of French cyclists tend to take matters into their own hands, without the input of a tour operator<sup>1</sup>.

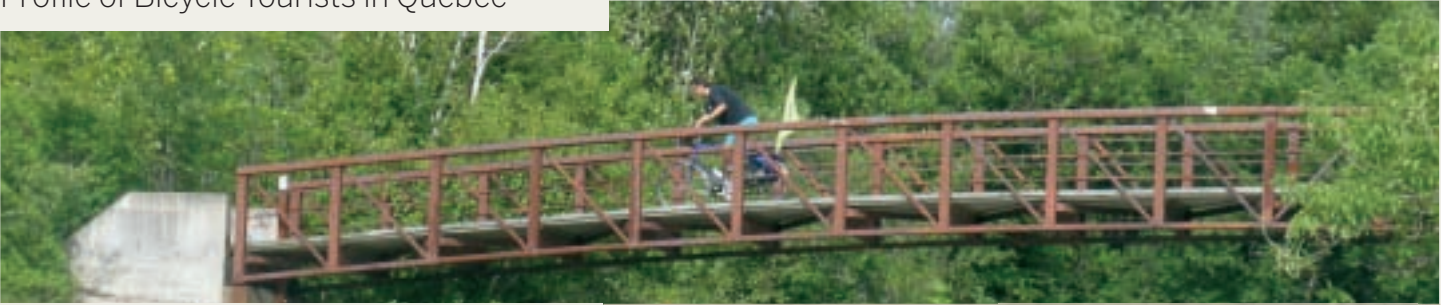
In France, under the auspices of the FFCT, **various initiatives** are in place to help develop bicycle touring. The nine Diagonale routes, for example, crisscross the country from peak to peak. The Brevet routes, on the other hand, are adapted to various age groups, with circuits of predetermined lengths and times. There are options for beginners, mountain bikers, campers and orienteers – all of which are excellent ways to discover bicycle touring and the many bikeroutes in each region. And the highlight of the summer is undoubtedly the Semaine fédérale event, which brings together more than 14,000 cyclists to explore the routes of a given region over an entire week.

On the other side of the Atlantic Ocean, the six-day Grand Tour and the family-oriented three-day Petite Aventure are the flagship events for bicycle touring in Québec. Not only do these activities help promote cycling, they also make a significant contribution to the local economy.

The **choice of terrain** is also more important for French cyclists than their Québec peers, especially considering how steep the mountain trails can be. Some prefer to head for the hills, while others opt for flatter ground. The difference is not as dramatic in Québec, although we certainly all know someone who would prefer the fields of the Eastern Townships to the inclines of the Charlevoix region.

Most individual cyclists also choose their destination based on the route-side **services**. Cyclists always appreciate the usual amenities: washrooms, grocery stores, restaurants, lodging and so forth. Over and above this, however, there can be services adapted specifically to their needs, such as concrete seaside lockers in Norway where cyclists can leave their personal effects while enjoying some time on the beach. Or, closer

## Profile of Bicycle Tourists in Québec



|                                                    | Athletic bicycle tourists | Vacationing bicycle tourists |
|----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------------|
| Number of bicycle tourists                         | 200 000                   | 400 000                      |
| Most common age range                              | 45-64 (44%)               | 18-34 (40%)                  |
| Number of trips involving cycling (per tourist)    | 2.2                       | 3.5                          |
| Number of days on trip spent cycling (per tourist) | 6.8                       | 5.4                          |
| Type of accommodations during the longest tour     |                           |                              |
| hotels and B&Bs                                    | 53%                       | 35%                          |
| campgrounds                                        | 32%                       | 33%                          |
| friend's homes, cottages, etc.                     | 12%                       | 25%                          |

Source: *Bicycling in Québec in 2005*, Vélo Québec Association (2006)

Bicycle tourists can be divided up into two main categories:

- Ⓢ Sports cyclists, for whom cycling is the core of their tourism experience
- Ⓡ Recreational cyclists, for whom cycling is an occasional or impromptu activity while travelling.

“The Vías Verdes is being touted as a new and fun way to enjoy an active, environmentally friendly vacation and as the best alternative to the traditional ‘sun and beach’ approach.”

Carmen Aycart Luengo



to home, certified “Bienvenue cyclistes!” facilities have been become very popular and could be expanded to include a luggage transportation option.

The question of **public transit** often comes up in the cycling world. In the United States, there are some 50,000 city buses equipped with bike racks, mainly for use by local commuters. Tourists, as a rule, tend to travel by train, and rail services can vary tremendously from one country to the next. Vicki Baron is very critical of how complicated it can be to get a bicycle on board a train in Ontario, compared to the convenience of the Swiss railways, which transport some 450,000 bikes every year.

The **type of infrastructure** also has an influence over certain types of users. Take the Vías Verdes in Spain, for example, which is entirely built along former railway rights-of-way. Carmen Aycart Luengo confirmed that this type of system appeals to travellers, but less to more serious cyclists.

**Prevailing trends** can also affect the choice of destination. In France, leisure travellers are now looking for destinations where they can leave their car behind for a week or two. Seaside resorts along the Atlantic coast have responded to this demand by increasing the number of beach trails, introducing bike rental services and adjusting their traffic planning accordingly. Some sections of seaside streets have been closed to motorists, while extra cycling paths have been developed. Cy-

1. *L'impact économique des véloroutes et voies vertes*, Agence française d'ingénierie touristique (AFIT) (2003). ([www.odit-france.fr](http://www.odit-france.fr))





GAËTAN FONTAINE

"Europe would be an easy market for a product like the Route verte. Switzerland, Germany and Scandinavia represent a market of 3 million cyclists and active travellers. Québec has not yet solidified its brand image as a cycling destination."  
Nicolas Mercat

cling traffic has therefore exploded, as the number of vehicles has dropped.

Nicolas Mercat, who has cycled all over the world, put forward some of the considerations that he himself has taken into account and that made his family trek through Québec particularly enjoyable, namely the wide range of landscapes (not just trees!), the quality of the national parks and the excellent cuisine.

It is important to be familiar with the broad array of **tools** used by cycle tourists to plan their trips and expeditions – from the ever-popular books, brochures, maps, guidebooks and magazines to the new dominant source of information: the Web.

Once they have gained a better understanding of the considerations of bicycle tourists and the sources of information available to them, organizations can reach out to them and promote their products. In this sense, Québec's Route verte has all of the ingredients ready to accommodate cyclists from around the world. Much still needs to be done, however, before this becomes a reality.

The need for advertising campaigns aimed at foreign visitors is clear. The involvement of the tourism ministries in this regard varies greatly from one administration to the next. Overall, federal entities (departments and agencies) tend to relegate cycling to such a specialized niche that it is very difficult to drum up any form of spontaneous enthusiasm.

### Pierre Reuzé

Fédération française  
de cyclotourisme, France

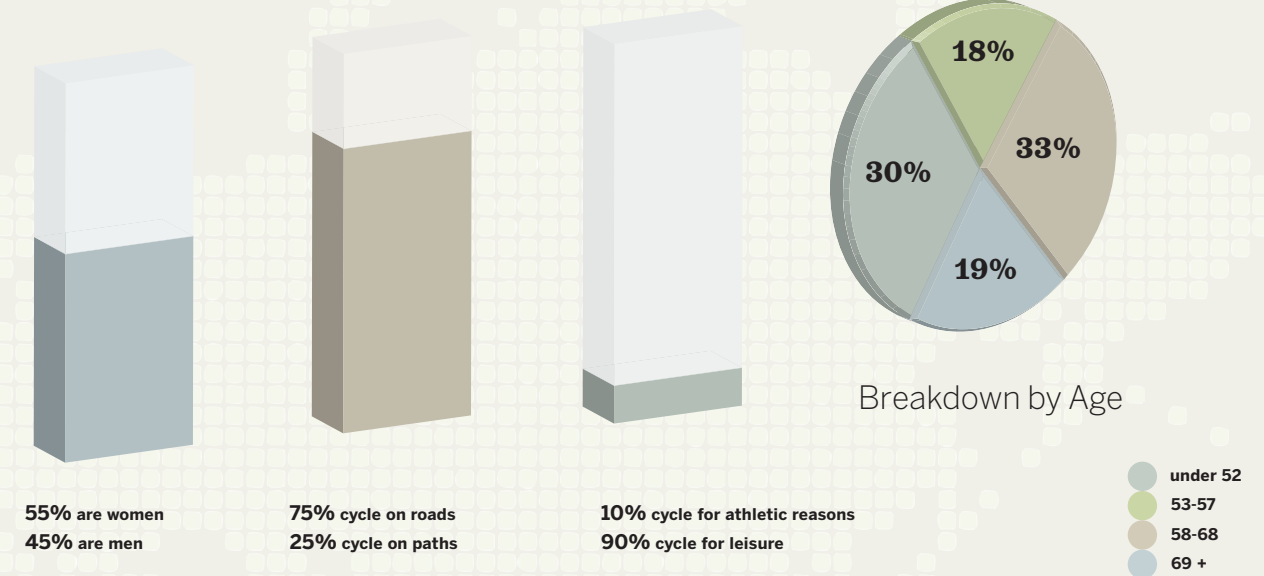
Pierre Reuzé comes to cycling after many years in the manufacturing industry, where quality control was one of his specialties. He is a volunteer with the Fédération française de cyclotourisme (FFCT), for which he has been in charge of international relations since 2000. He is also the President of the Union européenne de cyclotourisme and Vice-President of the Union internationale de cyclotourisme. Founded in 1923, the FFCT, with a membership of 120,000, is the largest association of cycling enthusiasts in the world. Its mission is to promote the use of cycling paths, lanes and trails. The FFCT is involved in the initiative to converge French and European interests with respect to the Association française des véloroutes et voies vertes (AF3V). The FFCT is a state-approved association covering a wide range of activities, including tourism, non-competitive sports, health and culture.



PIERRE REUZÉ

[www.ffct.org](http://www.ffct.org)

### Profile of Users of FFCT Bikerides



"Advertising works. The North Sea Cycle Route has seen a 30% annual increase in its number of cyclists, mainly because the product is better known."

Eli Viten

## HIGHLIGHTS

### Selection of Destination

- Ⓢ Most individual cyclists choose their destination based on nearby services and amenities.
- Ⓢ The type of infrastructure has an influence on user profile.
- Ⓢ Vacationers are increasingly on the lookout for car-free holiday destinations.
- Ⓢ National cycling networks need to advertise internationally to maximize their visibility and appeal.

When funds are short, marketing initiatives must be even more creative. Vías Verdes, for example, ingeniously included a guide to its bikeway network in the Spanish government's official roadmap, which sells 120,000 copies a year. At this scale, the guide is not particularly practical, but it serves to publicize the presence of the network in the various regions.

In Ontario, a partnership has been concluded with MapArt, a leading publisher of roadmaps. MapArt makes and sells detailed maps of the Ontario Waterfront Trail, thereby ensuring that the corporation in charge of the trail does not incur any financial risk. In addition, the trail circuits and logo are clearly indicated on all MapArt roadmaps.

A simple and affordable way of reaching cyclists is to team up with like-minded organizations. The League of American Bicyclists has 25,000 members, which it reaches through the magazine *American Bicyclist*. The Fédération française de cyclotourisme reaches 120,000 people via *Cyclotourisme*, which is also sold on newsstands. The Adventure Cycling Association publishes *Adventure Cyclist* nine times a year and distributes copies to its 42,500 members. Publications of this nature therefore represent an easy way of getting the word out to potential clients.







GAËTAN FONTAINE

## Information for Cycle Tourists “Can We Help You?”

The quality and quantity of information available on a destination are decisive factors for individual travellers. Before leaving, they need to find information, plan their itinerary and book their accommodations. When they arrive, they have to be able to orient themselves and make decisions. They therefore need a way to get prompt, accurate answers to their questions. Beyond that, however, they are also looking for the “wow” factor – a new experience that will tip the scales. So promotion and advertising are a must. The marketing and visibility strategies proposed by the participants of the International Mobile Forum are interesting in terms of both their similarities and their differences.

### On Site

Vicki Barron, from Ontario’s Waterfront Trail, explains that the 83 trailhead signs posted at strategic locations have been particularly effective. The two-sided signs are provided by the organization and installed by the municipalities. They feature a map of the entire trail and indicate the distances between communities. Sponsors’ logos are clearly displayed, along with the website address of the Waterfront Regeneration Trust.

On-site information helps cyclists get their geographical bearings and determine the location of nearby roads, services and communities. Kilometre and trail markers are also very useful. There was even mention of a trail in France where markers are installed at 100-metre increments. Although intended primarily for runners, these markers could come in handy for cyclists as well.

### In Print

Cycle tourists will tell you that nothing beats a good old-fashioned paper map. Bikeway associations must therefore ensure that detailed maps are available in print format, preferably on a section-by-section basis. The Waterfront Trail’s Mapbook is

### Vicki Barron

Waterfront Trail, Ontario, Canada

Vicki Barron is Director of Administration and Special Projects of the Waterfront Regeneration Trust, a not-for-profit organization founded in 1999 to oversee the development of the Waterfront Trail. This multi-use recreational trail, which is 90% complete, connects 41 communities from Niagara to Québec along the Canadian shores of Lake Ontario. Since 2005, the Waterfront Regeneration Trust and Vélo Québec have been working together to mobilize the communities in the Cornwall-Montréal corridor to complete the trail. Before joining the Waterfront Regeneration Trust, Vicki Barron was the Director General of the Credit Valley Conservation, an environmental organization dedicated to preserving and enhancing watershed natural resources. She has been honoured for her environmental efforts by the Canadian Water Resources Association.

[www.waterfronttrail.org](http://www.waterfronttrail.org)



GILLES MORNEAU

### Jim Sayer

Adventure Cycling Association, USA

Jim Sayer is the Executive Director of the Adventure Cycling Association, America’s premier non-profit organization dedicated to bicycle travel. The Association’s mission is to inspire people of all ages to travel by bicycle. The Adventure Cycling Association recently teamed up with the American Association of State Highway and Transportation Officials (AASHTO) to establish a national route system, which would eventually be linked to Canada as well.

Jim Sayer did his undergraduate studies at the University of California, Santa Barbara, and the University of Edinburgh, in Scotland. He went on to graduate from the Fletcher School of Law and Diplomacy and Harvard University. He has headed up several not-for-profit organizations involved in transportation and sustainable development in addition to acting as the Senior Legislative Assistant for Senator Tim Wirth (Colorado). He volunteers with a number of organizations, including Amnesty International USA and the Ginetta Sagan Fund for women’s and children’s rights.

[www.adv-cycling.org](http://www.adv-cycling.org)



GILLES MORNEAU



published by MapArt and printed on demand, which keeps financial and material losses to a minimum and facilitates the updating process. The price of the Mapbook is under \$30. Individual maps can be downloaded from the Internet and printed out for free. Simplified guides to shorter routes (under two hours), complete with maps, directions and a list of nearby attractions, are also distributed free of charge to local users.

With the upcoming launch of SwitzerlandMobility in 2008, Switzerland is updating its guidebooks to include details on the various routes. In Spain, the Vías Verdes has been featured in several publications, with maps, detailed histories and the attractions of the various regions. La Route verte du Québec is a section-by-section guide that includes information on bypass routes where there is a break in the network. And in Germany, there are several competing guides available, especially for the D-Routes and the popular Bett & Bike network, which was in part the inspiration for the “Bienvenue cyclistes!” initiative in Québec.

Jim Sayer of the Adventure Cycling Association in the U.S. explained that the main goal of his organization when it was founded in 1976 was to provide detailed maps of a cross-country route. Thirty years later, with 42,500 members and 31,180 miles of bikeways, the association offers 34 tour packages (ranging from three to 93 days) and oversees some 20 annual events in addition to several education programs.

The laminated maps of the various bicycle routes in the U.S. are still in great demand, but the organization now also provides other kinds of information, such as the cycling Yellow Pages, the print version of which is read by 70,000 people a year. The online directory is consulted by no fewer than 1 million people a year. The association has also published a series of guides with basic information for travellers, including the online How-To Department guide, which provides a wealth of practical tips and handy links.



## Online

The Web is now the leading source of tourism information. To effectively reach and inform travellers, organizations need to have a comprehensive and up-to-date website. Lukas Stadtherr underscored the importance of creating a portal to help users plan their trip, connect with service providers and diversify their experience (cycling, mountain biking, canoeing, kayaking, etc.). He recommended using a single, distinctive brand and a consistent set of colours and visuals in all media (online, print, on-site signage) to maximize user recognition and convenience. The Cycling in Switzerland website is visited 300,000 a year. The Waterfront Trail website has 210,000 unique visitors, for more than 5 million hits, often-times for the free downloadable maps. In 2007, the Route verte website welcomed 500,000 unique visitors.

In addition to the basic information on services and routes, a good website provides up-to-the-minute information on road work, weather and other details critical to cyclists.

The Adventure Cycling Association has even added an innovative new feature for users of GPS technology, of which there are growing numbers. A list of waypoints can be downloaded free of charge from the website to users' GPS systems. Cyclists can then confirm their position at any point and make the most of their maps.

In the vast jungle of tourism-oriented websites, good indexing and clear keywords are essential for ensuring visibility in search engine results.

## Promotion

Organizations need to know how to put their people and tools to good use to secure maximum visibility and exposure. In Spain, a series of eye-catching television specials has been produced on the Vías Verdes, and local media are used whenever possible. The public is also very involved in the organization of an annual celebration of the country's greenways.

Bernhard Ensink indicated that the European Cyclists Federation arranges tours of its routes specifically for journalists. He added that teamwork among the various partners is vital to ensuring that expertise and information are disseminated effectively around the country and across the world. Cyclists should not have to jump through hoops to track down the travel information they are looking for. Boards, administrators and coordinating committees need to be in constant communication and speak in a single, unified voice when it comes to promoting their bikeways.

Bernhard Ensink, Carmen Aycart Luengo and Vicki Barron all publish electronic newsletters. The Ontario Waterfront



"In the United States, different organizations are in charge of different things. There is no one organization like Vélo Québec to oversee travel information, publications, advocacy and so forth."

Andy Clarke

## HIGHLIGHTS



### Information for Cycle Tourists

- ② Individual cycle tourists are constantly looking for information.
- ② The Web is the leading source of tourism information. Organizations need to make a comprehensive, regularly updated website available to potential clients.
- ② It is in the best interest of all stakeholders to work together to ensure the development, marketing and branding of major cycling destinations (EuroVelo, North Sea Cycle Route, etc.).
- ② Despite the undeniable dominance of the Internet and the growing interest in GPS technologies, accurate printed maps and guides remain essential.
- ② Cyclist stations, such as the Maison des cyclistes in Montréal, and the remodeled train stations that International Mobile Forum participants visited in Saint-Jérôme, Prévost, Sainte-Adèle, Warwick and Victoriaville, make the cycling experience more personal and welcoming.

Trail's *ShoreEzine* is intended for users and service providers. A modified version focusing on more specific issues is sent to community partners. A relatively small amount of effort and money go into these tools, but the payoff in terms of communication with various stakeholders is great. And as an internal resource, they help stimulate new ideas and keep everyone motivated and well informed.

The Fédération française de cyclotourisme, the League of American Bicyclists and Adventure Cycling all publish magazines for their members. These are excellent ways to promote tourist destinations. Most organizations also make a point of attending various cycling shows and exhibitions to ensure optimal exposure.

### A Special Place ... Just for Cyclists!

The participants of the International Mobile Forum felt that Vélo Québec's Maison des cyclistes is an inspired idea and a way of establishing a home base for a bikeway network. Travellers enjoy stopping in, talking to fellow enthusiasts and getting the information they need.

The headquarters of the Adventure Cycling Association in Missoula, Montana, are located in a former church. Visiting cyclists are greeted with an ice cream cone and a cold drink. A Polaroid picture is taken of them and posted on the wall of fame.

All of these examples clearly illustrate the importance of national networks, such as the Route verte, working together toward the development, marketing and branding of major destinations and attractions.





JOHN LING

# Signage and Continuous Improvement

## Better and Better

There is no such thing as the perfect bikeway network. There are always improvements to be made, although generally with a tight budget. Determining which courses of action should be prioritized requires a degree of objectivity. It is often useful to examine what is being done elsewhere. A number of presentations at the International Mobile Forum addressed this point and highlighted some interesting approaches to branding, quality criteria, signage and evaluation.

The Route verte already enjoys solid visibility. A survey conducted in August 2007 revealed that two out of three people in Québec have heard of the Route verte, almost double the percentage recorded just two years ago. The signs that have been going up since 1996 alongside the route and other trails, often as a complement to regional and local signage, are helping to secure this visibility.

## Brand image

Carmen Aycart Luengo stressed that a cycling network's brand, if it is managed properly, has a major impact on its visibility. Bearing this in mind, the managers of the Vías Verdes in Spain have opted to use a consistent, high-quality brand image in all signage posted along the network of former railway rights-of-way.

Bernhard Ensink, of the European Cyclists Federation, expressed similar thoughts, although on a larger scale, given that the network he works with covers an entire continent. He explained that he has to project a consistent image, while still taking into account the individual character of each country where the network is present. For the ECF, rigour, without overshadowing the distinctiveness of each bikeway, is essential. For example, Route 6 is never called "Route 6" by itself.

## Bernhard Ensink

European Cyclists Federation (ECF), Belgium

Bernhard Ensink is with the European Cyclists Federation (ECF), an association of various national cycling associations from Europe as well as a dozen members from other countries and regions, including the United States, Australia, New Zealand, South Africa and Québec. The ECF is overseeing the development of the EuroVelo network of 12 long-distance bikeways running across Europe. The total length of the routes will top 60,000 kilometres, a third of which has already been completed. The ECF was founded in 1983 in order to help capitalize on the potential of bicycles as a sustainable means of transportation and a way of achieving optimal quality of life. The ECF is also the driving force behind the Velo-City conference, the most recent edition of which was held in Munich from June 12 to 15, 2007. Montréal hosted Velo-City in 1992.

[www.ecf.com](http://www.ecf.com)



LUKAS STADTHER

## Lukas Stadtherr

Cycling in Switzerland/Velobüro, Switzerland

Lukas Stadtherr has been the co-director of Velobüro since 2003. Velobüro is mandated by the federal and regional governments to coordinate the development and promotion of Cycling in Switzerland, a group of nine cycling routes running through the various regions of the country. Velobüro is involved in signage, the production of maps, the design and maintenance of the online portal and relations with partners, including public transportation and hospitality service providers. Lukas Stadtherr studied business administration (College of Economy and Administration, Berne) and land-use planning (College of Advanced Technology of Brugg-Windisch). He is a senior executive with SwitzerlandMobility, a joint initiative of the national and regional governments, as well as transportation, tourism and sports agencies, to develop a network of bikeways that promote sustainable mobility for recreational and tourism purposes. Lukas is the Swiss representative for the EuroVelo Route 6 project, which covers 4,000 kilometres between the Atlantic Ocean and the North Sea.

[www.velobuero.ch](http://www.velobuero.ch)



BERNHARD ENSINK



It is always referred to as "Route 6, from the Atlantic Ocean to the Black Sea."

## Quality Criteria

The European Cyclists Federation reviewed the quality of its networks based on the following factors: users' needs, tourists' needs, intermodality, safety, parking and signage.

The criteria put forward by the Association des Départements cyclables are even more stringent:

- ⊗ Definition of targets, use and users (family recreation, local commutes, tourism, sport).

"A consistent image across the board definitely helps national and international promotional efforts."

Carmen Aycart Luengo

- ⊗ Selection of the right type of bikeway:
  - ⊗ greenways and bikeways in rural and suburban settings
  - ⊗ bike paths and lanes in urban settings
  - ⊗ integration into road planning (one-way streets, bicycle-only streets, etc.).
- ⊗ Adaptation of road surfaces to various purposes (urban, rural, natural, tourism, intersections, etc.).
- ⊗ Technical characteristics of methods to be adopted to improve the quality of bikeway surfaces, depending on the purpose.
- ⊗ Selective use of restricted-access methods (remove when not required or ensure chicanes are wide enough to accommodate tandem bicycles, bicycle trailers, etc.).
- ⊗ Integration into the surrounding landscape and environment.
- ⊗ Incorporation of rest and service stops:
  - ⊗ to maximize economic benefits
  - ⊗ to ensure adequate access to water (5 to 10 kilometres between points).
- ⊗ Parking facilities for vehicles (short and long term) and bicycles at activities and attractions.
- ⊗ Landscaping and design:
  - ⊗ contests at architectural and design schools
  - ⊗ variety (open/closed, greenways/small roads)
  - ⊗ handling of contentious intersections
  - ⊗ emphasis on vistas.

## Signage

The signage recently developed for EuroVelo, with its characteristic yellow stars against a blue square, is highly recognizable. This image identifies the route number and is integrated into the national, regional and local road signs in various countries.

The signage for the SwitzerlandMobility network bears all the hallmarks of its Swiss heritage: precision, standardization and rigour. The same visual appears on all signs, online applications, private and commercial displays and so forth. The system is applied at a national, regional and local level. Information is simple and concise, although still presented in a warm, appealing way. And the same approach is used through-



out the SwitzerlandMobility network (hiking, inline skating, mountain biking and canoeing). The visuals used are the same – only the colour palette changes. The result is instant user recognition and clarity.

This impressive system will be up and running by the spring of 2008. “The 45,000 signs will be in place by the April 26 deadline – at 7:30 a.m. sharp!” said Lukas Stadtherr, jokingly referring to the Swiss reputation for punctuality. Mind you, with the reputation of his entire nation at stake, the need for precision has never been greater!

GAËTAN FONTAINE



“Improvement requires a critical assessment of existing facilities, through surveys, interviews and metering.”  
Nicolas Mercat

### Evaluation

The participants of the International Mobile Forum said that they constantly changed their positions with respect to their users, in keeping with the findings of on-site surveys.

When planning a new facility, Nicolas Mercat said he starts by gathering as much information as possible. He then prepares a model to determine expected traffic levels and establishes development standards (width, surfacing, etc.). Once the facilities are in place, he evaluates them, using mini-questionnaires, comprehensive surveys and automated and manual meters. This invaluable feedback sometimes leads to the adoption of new practices. For example, his restricted-access systems have evolved in response to user demand. The chicanes used have been spaced more widely to accommodate tandems and bicycle trailers. And rigid signposts were removed after a series of accidents.

Vicki Barron has also learned some valuable lessons from data collected annually by volunteers on site at the Ontario Waterfront Trail. Even though the trail is primarily intended to serve local residents who are supposedly familiar with the surroundings, polls showed that there were signage problems, which were duly corrected.



## HIGHLIGHTS



### Signage and Continuous Improvement

- Ⓢ The branding of a network, when properly managed, has a strong impact on its visibility.
- Ⓢ National and international networks must project a consistent image, while still respecting the individual character of the networks of the various regions and countries they serve.
- Ⓢ The long-term viability of a network depends on stringent evaluation and the application of quality criteria in day-to-day management.
- Ⓢ To ensure maximum clarity for cyclists, a consistent set of visuals should be used on all signs, online applications and private and commercial displays.
- Ⓢ The continuous improvement process requires information on usage (metering), perception of needs (surveys) and behavioural tendencies (monitoring) of cycle tourists.

### Analysis

In the final analysis, how does the Route verte measure up from these various perspectives? To begin with, the branding of the network has been a tremendous success that is often cited by other organizations.

The route markers follow strict standards and contribute to the overall quality of the bikeway network. They are acknowledged by Transports Québec in its graphic standards manual, thereby confirming their official status. At borders and interregional junctures, Route verte signage is displayed at tourist facilities to promote the network and to direct users toward it. Vélo Québec proudly presented a miniature Route verte marker to speakers and VIPs attending the International Mobile Forum.

With this marker and the accompanying information panels, the Route verte has been successful in the signage aspect of its mandate. The vastness of the area to be covered in Québec makes the job easier, especially compared to the situation in Europe, where the dense populations and high number of routes complicate matters. However, there are still potential pitfalls in that signage ultimately depends on the good will and efforts of network administrators.

Based on their own quality criteria, the participants of the International Mobile Forum confirmed that the Route verte enjoys a solid image. Its main strengths are landscaping, parking facilities, service stops and bikeway surfaces.

The evaluation tool available to the Route verte is a document known as *Bicycling in Québec*. Produced every five years, *Bicycling in Québec* is a report on the latest developments in the cycling community. It contains a number of general surveys that make it possible to measure the Route verte popularity. However, based on the practices used by the participants of the International Mobile Forum, it would be preferable to gather more information on site, directly from the users themselves. A section of the French version of the Vélo Québec website entitled “Vigie cycliste” allows users to share with their elected officials any problems they encounter. This function should also be incorporated into the Route verte site.

The continuous improvement of the Route verte, like its maintenance and upkeep, is contingent upon the ability to secure the appropriate funding. There are already several programs in place with various municipalities for maintenance and development. Transports Québec has also issued a cycling policy to contribute to the development, improvement and maintenance of the Route verte and other bikeways overseen by the transportation ministry. Other programs designed to promote continuous improvement must be established.





ON THE OCCASION OF THE INTERNATIONAL MOBILE FORUM ON THE ROUTE VERTE, WHICH TOOK PLACE FROM AUGUST 5 TO 10, 2007, IN THE PRESENCE OF:

**Carmen Aycart Luengo**

Vías Verdes, Spain

**Vicki Barron**

Waterfront Trail, Ontario

**Louis Carpentier**

Vélo Québec Association

**Andy Clarke**

League of American Bicyclists, USA

**Bernhard Ensink**

European Cyclists Federation (ECF), Belgium

**Marc Jolicœur**

Vélo Québec Association

**Suzanne Lareau**

Vélo Québec

**Nicolas Mercat**

Association des Départements cyclables, France

**Marc Panneton**

Ministère des Transports du Québec

**Réjean Parent**

Association des Réseaux cyclables du Québec

**Jean-François Pronovost**

Vélo Québec Association

**Pierre Reuzé**

Fédération française de cyclotourisme, France

**Jim Sayer**

Adventure Cycling Association, USA

**Lukas Stadtherr**

La Suisse à vélo / Velobüro, Switzerland

**Eli Viten**

North Sea Cycle Route, Norway



CLAUDE GILL

## THE «2007 ROUTE VERTE» DECLARATION

THE PARTICIPANTS DECLARE THAT MAJOR WORLD-CLASS BICYCLE ROUTES AND ROUTE NETWORKS, SUCH AS THE ROUTE VERTE IN QUEBEC, ARE KEY PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURES WHOSE DEVELOPMENT AND SUSTAINABILITY CONTRIBUTE TO THE WELL-BEING OF THE GENERAL POPULATION.

① The bicycle is a zero-emission, climate friendly vehicle that is accessible to all and that has a minimal impact on the surrounding environment in terms of safety, noise, road space occupied and parking.

② Bicycling is an active means of transportation that promotes individual and collective health and well-being.

③ Bicycle tourism is an environmentally friendly, healthy and enriching way to explore the culture, attractions and cuisine of a region or country.

④ Bicycle tourism has a more significant economic impact, locally and per individual, than traditional tourism and also encourages people to adopt healthy lifestyles, particularly through the promotion of active transportation.

⑤ The infrastructures required for bicycle tourism, particularly bikeways and greenways, are also public recreational and transportation facilities that benefit the population as a whole and promote cycling.

⑥ The safety of touring cyclists in particular and cyclists in general must be ensured on bicycle paths as well as on the road network through the development of high-quality infrastructures, including signage aimed specifically at cyclists.

⑦ The services required by touring cyclists—accommodations, restaurants, baggage and bicycle transportation, etc.—contribute to regional economic development. Access to such services is one of the keys to the success of bicycle routes.

⑧ The transportation of bicycles on board trains, planes and buses is essential to the development of bicycle tourism.

Consequently, the participants in the International Mobile Forum on the Route verte urge the government, the municipalities and the partner organizations to complete the Route verte, to provide for its sustainable development and long-term viability, and to link the bicycle route to networks in neighbouring provinces and states as well as to regional and local networks allowing cyclists to explore Quebec in greater depth.